

What Is Laravel?

Laravel is a popular open-source PHP web framework designed for building modern, scalable, and secure web applications. It is an opinionated and a high-level framework. I'll talk more about what that means in a minute. It also follows the Model-View-Controller (MVC) architectural pattern, which we'll get into later, and it aims to make the development process more efficient and enjoyable.

I'm sure most of you are aware of what a web framework is, but just in case you aren't, it's a collection of libraries and tools that help developers build applications faster by providing common functionality, such as routing, database management, and authentication. If you took my PHP from scratch course and create the Workopia project, then you know that just using PHP can be a bit cumbersome and repetitive and even messy. Laravel and frameworks in general make things much easier and more organized.

Laravel was created by Taylor Otwell in 2011 and has since become what I would say the most popular PHP framework. It's known for its expressive syntax, robust features, and active community. Laravel is used by developers around the world to build a wide range of applications, from simple blogs to complex enterprise systems.

Usually when people learn PHP, they go in one of two directions. They either learn WordPress or they learn Laravel. Wordpress is more for smaller content-based websites and blogs, while Laravel is for more complex applications. And there is nothing that says that you can't learn both.

Opinionated Framework

Laravel is an opinionated framework, which means it comes with a set of conventions and best practices that guide developers in building applications. This can be a good thing because you usually get a ton of features right out of the box, it helps maintain consistency across projects and makes it easier for developers to collaborate. However, it can also be restrictive if you prefer more flexibility and control over your code.

If you have ever used Ruby On Rails, Django or Angular, then you know what an opinionated framework is. There are a lot of features and conventions. If you have used Express.js or React, those are very unopinionated frameworks where you don't need to do things a certain way. You have a lot of freedom, but you also have to make a lot of decisions and don't get many out of the box features. There are pros and cons to both approaches.

Why Use Laravel?

There are a ton of reasons to use Laravel for your projects. This is a list of some of the common ones. It's not a complete list, but it's a start.

- **Rapid Development:** Laravel streamlines common tasks like routing, authentication, and database management, allowing developers to focus on building features rather than reinventing the wheel.
- **Security:** With built-in features for protecting against SQL injection, cross-site request forgery (CSRF), and cross-site scripting (XSS), Laravel helps ensure that your application is secure from common vulnerabilities.
- **Scalability:** The framework is designed to handle growth, making it suitable for both small projects and large enterprise applications.

- **Built-in Authentication:** It provides built-in authentication and authorization features, making it easier to manage user access and security.
- **Elegant Syntax:** Laravel offers a clean and elegant syntax that allows developers to write code that is both readable and maintainable.
- **Robust Ecosystem:** Laravel has a rich ecosystem with tools and features such as Eloquent ORM, Blade templating engine.
- **Migration System:** Laravel offers database tools. It has a complete migration system to manage database schema changes, making it easier to collaborate with teams and maintain consistency. Eloquent ORM to interact with the database as well as factories and seeding to quickly add data.
- **Community Support:** Laravel has a large and active community, which means you can find plenty of tutorials, documentation, and third-party packages to enhance your project.
- **Task Scheduling:** The framework includes a task scheduling system, which lets you automate repetitive tasks using a clean, fluent API.
- **Testing:** Laravel comes with tools for automated testing, which helps ensure your code is reliable and free of bugs.

There are so many more features, but these are some of the key ones that make Laravel so popular. In the next video I will give you a large list of the features and libraries that are come built in to the framework.